Security Council Manual

Supplement for Chairs and Delegates

This Manual explains the procedures and working methods specific to the Security Council (SC) at MoMUN. It is intended for both delegates and Student Officers, and should be read alongside the general Delegate and Student Officer Manuals. The general manuals explain participation, Points, Motions, speeches, yielding the floor and resolution formatting; this supplement explains how these procedures apply within the Council.

The Security Council differs from other committees primarily in its mandate, membership and voting requirements. Delegates should use this Manual when preparing proposals and deciding how to vote. Chairs should use it when organising debate, checking amendments and announcing the outcome of a vote.

The MoMUN Code of Conduct applies separately. Its provisions are not reproduced here; participants should consult the official text for conduct, academic integrity, electronic devices, safety and reporting concerns. [1]

The conference procedures described here follow the supplied Student Officer Manual, with the Council-specific voting rules explained below. United Nations references explain the Council's mandate and voting system; they do not automatically introduce every procedure used at United Nations meetings into MoMUN.

Table of Contents

THE SECURITY COUNCIL **3**

Membership 3
Mandate 3
Invited Participants 3

OPENING THE SESSION **4**

Roll Call and Quorum 4
Initial Clarifications 4
Preparing for Debate 4

DEBATE AND NEGOTIATION **5**

Lobbying 5
Modes of Debate 5
The Veto in Negotiation 5
Consultations and Crisis Updates 5

RESOLUTIONS AND AMENDMENTS **6**

Drafting Council Measures 6
Submitting Amendments 6
Debating and Deciding Amendments 6

VOTING **7**

Procedural and Substantive Matters 7
Conducting the Vote 7
Announcing the Result 7
Special Voting Questions 7

THE RIGHT TO VETO **8**

Who May Exercise a Veto 8
Casting and Recording a Veto 8
Abstentions and Procedural Matters 8
Responding to a Veto 8

PRACTICAL EXAMPLES **9**

Voting Examples 9
Amendment Example 9
Revising a Proposal after Rejection 9

SESSION CHECKLIST AND FINAL REMARKS **10**

For Delegates 10
For Chairs 10
Final Remarks 10

REFERENCES **11**

The Security Council

Membership

The Council consists of fifteen Member States: five permanent members and ten non-permanent members. The permanent members are China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom and the United States of America. Each Council member has one vote. [6]

Delegates should use the allocation list issued for their MoMUN committee. Chairs should check the fifteen Council seats against this list and identify the five permanent members clearly on the Roll Call Sheet. Invited participants should be recorded separately from voting Council members.

Permanent membership does not grant priority when requesting the floor, submitting an amendment or raising a Point. Chairs should give all delegations a fair opportunity to participate. Non-permanent members should take an active role in drafting, negotiation and debate.

Mandate

The Council has primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. Its proposals should address the security implications of the agenda topic and identify actions that the Council can reasonably take. [3]

Under Chapter VI of the UN Charter, the Council may support the peaceful settlement of disputes. Under Chapter VII, it may determine that a threat to peace, breach of peace or act of aggression exists and consider measures in response. Article 41 concerns measures without armed force; Article 42 concerns action involving force where Article 41 measures would be inadequate or have proved inadequate. [3]

Delegates should distinguish between recommending an action, requesting assistance and deciding upon a measure within the Council's authority. Stronger language should be supported by a clear purpose, an appropriate basis and a workable means of implementation. The use of the word "Decides" does not, by itself, establish that a proposal falls within the Council's powers.

Invited Participants

States outside the Council may participate in relevant discussions under the conditions provided in Articles 31 and 32 of the Charter, without a vote. Rules 37–39 of the Council's Provisional Rules also address invitations and assistance from briefers. [3, 4]

At MoMUN, an invitation or briefing must be arranged through the Chairs and Responsible Secretariat Member. Delegates may request that relevant perspectives be heard, but should not assume that another delegation or an external participant can enter proceedings without authorisation. Invited participants do not increase the number of Council members or acquire voting rights.

Opening the Session

Roll Call and Quorum

The attendance and Roll Call procedures in the general Student Officer Manual continue to apply. Delegates should respond when their delegation is called and inform the Chairs if their attendance changes. Chairs should update the Roll Call Sheet before each session and before voting where necessary.

The supplied general Manual sets quorum at one third of the House. Applied to a Council of fifteen voting members, this is five members present, unless the Secretariat issues a specific Security Council quorum rule. Invited participants are not counted as Council members for this purpose. This conference quorum should not be confused with the nine affirmative votes required to adopt a decision.

Meeting quorum does not reduce the adoption threshold. For example, if only eight Council members are present, the Council cannot obtain the nine votes needed to adopt a resolution. Chairs should address attendance concerns with the Responsible Secretariat Member before attempting a vote that cannot meet the required threshold.

Initial Clarifications

Before substantive debate begins, Chairs should explain the nine-vote threshold, identify the permanent members, and clarify the distinction between a vote against and an abstention. They should also announce the method for submitting amendments and identify the version of each document that the committee will use.

Delegates should raise a Point of Parliamentary Inquiry if a procedure is unclear. Any conference-specific arrangement should be explained to the whole Council before it is applied. Chairs should refer unresolved questions to the Responsible Secretariat Member rather than announce a new voting rule during a vote.

Preparing for Debate

Delegates should research their country's position, relevant Council action and the interests of other members. Preparation should identify proposals the delegation can support, changes it would seek, and the evidence needed to explain those positions. A delegation should be able to explain both its preferred outcome and the compromises it can consider.

Chairs should be familiar with the agenda topic and the Council's mandate, while remaining impartial between proposals. They should prepare the attendance record, document display and vote record, and agree on who will moderate debate, receive amendments and count votes.

Debate and Negotiation

Lobbying

The Lobbying procedure described in the general Manual applies. Delegates should work towards a coherent proposal rather than collect unrelated clauses. Early discussions should identify the main security problem, proposed response, responsibilities for implementation and points of disagreement.

The views of permanent members are relevant to whether a proposal can pass, but support from other Council members remains necessary. Delegates should seek workable wording across the Council and avoid treating negotiations as a discussion limited to the permanent members.

When a delegation objects to a clause, other delegates should ask which part creates the difficulty and what change would address it. A proposed compromise may concern the scope of a measure, its duration, reporting requirements or conditions for review. Delegates should assess the resulting text against their country's position before agreeing to it.

The general requirements for Main Submitters, co-submitters, correction and Approval Panel review continue to apply. Chairs should confirm that the text introduced for debate is the approved version and that delegates can identify the resolution and its current wording.

Modes of Debate

Unless a separate Security Council procedure has been issued by the Secretariat, resolutions are debated through Open Debate and amendments through Closed Debate, as described in the general Manual. The Council does not automatically move to clause-by-clause debate or adopt a new caucus system because it is a specialised committee.

Chairs should announce the item under consideration and the allotted debate time. During Open Debate, delegates may address the resolution as a whole or explain concerns about particular clauses. During Closed Debate on an amendment, speeches should address the proposed change and its effect on the resolution.

Points of Information, follow-ups, yielding the floor and the Right of Reply follow the general rules. Delegates should use a Point of Parliamentary Inquiry to clarify procedure and an amendment to propose a substantive change; a procedural Point does not change the text under discussion.

The Veto in Negotiation

A permanent member may explain that it cannot support the current wording and identify the changes it would seek. Such a statement informs negotiation; it does not itself constitute a veto or end debate. A veto takes effect through a negative vote on a substantive item. [5]

Chairs should allow other members to respond through the normal debate procedure. They should not remove a proposal solely because a permanent member has announced an intention to vote against it, or assume that a delegation's announced position replaces its actual vote.

Consultations and Crisis Updates

Where consultation or a crisis format is authorised, Chairs should announce its purpose, duration and any special submission rules. Formal debate resumes as directed; consultation does not replace adoption by vote.

For a crisis update, the Chairs should share the Secretariat's authorised information with the whole Council. Delegates should distinguish that information from their own assumptions. A crisis does not automatically change the agenda, voting requirements or Council authority.

Resolutions and Amendments

Drafting Council Measures

The structure, typography, numbering and punctuation requirements in the general Manual apply to Council resolutions. The forum should be identified as “Security Council (SC)”. Delegates should choose preambulatory and operative phrases that reflect the purpose and authority of each clause.

An operative clause should identify the action proposed, who is expected to carry it out and how progress would be assessed. Where relevant, it should state the area covered, duration, reporting arrangements and conditions for review. These details make a proposal easier to debate and reduce uncertainty about what a vote would approve.

For sanctions proposals, delegates should explain the intended targets, scope, implementation and review of the measure, and consider humanitarian effects. Proposals involving a mission should explain its purpose, tasks, duration and reporting arrangements. References to funding should follow the general Manual’s restriction on specifying exact financial amounts.

Delegates should check existing mechanisms before proposing a new body or mandate. Chairs should identify unclear responsibilities, contradictory clauses and actions outside the Council’s competence, and discuss corrections with the submitters before Approval Panel review.

Submitting Amendments

An amendment should identify the submitting delegation, the target clause, the type of change and its exact wording. It may add a clause, strike a clause or replace specified wording. Delegates should send it through the method announced by the Chairs; the general Manual does not require a separate paper form where another method has been agreed.

Each amendment should address one clause. If a proposal changes a sub-clause, the delegate should identify both the main clause and the relevant sub-clause. Where wording is replaced, the proposed text should be complete enough to insert directly into the resolution. Separate changes to different clauses require separate amendments.

Chairs should check relevance, formatting, mandate and remaining debate time before entertaining an amendment. Acceptance for debate does not mean that the amendment has been adopted. The text must be displayed or read clearly before the submitter delivers the first speech in favour.

Debating and Deciding Amendments

The general Closed Debate procedure and limits on second-degree amendments continue to apply. Substantive amendments are subject to the Council’s substantive voting requirements. An amendment does not avoid the veto merely because it is presented as a change to an existing proposal. [7]

If an amendment passes, Chairs should incorporate it into the working text before debate resumes. If it fails, the original wording remains. Adoption of an amendment does not adopt the resolution; the Council must still vote on the final resolution after debate has concluded.

Minor corrections that do not change substance should be handled under the general Manual’s provisions on formatting and grammatical corrections. A proposal that changes an obligation, target, scope or proposed action should not be passed automatically as a correction.

Voting

Procedural and Substantive Matters

A procedural matter concerns how the meeting proceeds. A substantive matter concerns what the Council proposes to do, including a draft resolution or an amendment changing its content. Chairs should identify the category and applicable voting requirement before calling a vote. [4]

Where a procedural question is put to a Council vote, nine affirmative votes are required and the veto does not apply. MoMUN's general rule against abstaining on procedural votes remains applicable. Motions that the general Manual assigns to the Chairs' discretion or resolves by seconds and objections do not automatically require a vote. [2, 4]

For substantive decisions, at least nine votes in favour are required and no permanent member may vote against. A permanent member may abstain without blocking adoption. An abstention does not count as a vote in favour and does not lower the threshold. [2]

Conducting the Vote

Before voting, Chairs should confirm quorum, identify the eligible Council members present, display the final text and explain whether the vote concerns a resolution or an amendment. Voting restrictions, note passing and entry to or exit from the room follow the general Manual.

Chairs should count votes in favour, votes against and abstentions separately. In a substantive vote, they must also identify whether a negative vote was cast by a permanent member. A roll call vote may be used where needed for an accurate record, under the general procedure.

Each delegation should cast one clear vote. If the count does not correspond to the eligible members present, or a vote is unclear, Chairs should resolve the discrepancy before announcing a final result. They should record any retaken vote as the operative vote and make that clear to the committee.

Announcing the Result

The announcement should state the totals and whether the item has been adopted. If it has not been adopted, Chairs should explain whether it failed to obtain nine affirmative votes, received a negative vote from a permanent member, or both. Delegates should be able to understand the result from the announcement alone. [5]

A simple majority of votes cast is not sufficient. Neither an extension of debate nor a Motion to Divide the House can remove the nine-vote requirement or the effect of a permanent member's negative vote. If the House is divided under the general procedure, the new vote must still be assessed under the Council's substantive requirements.

Special Voting Questions

Article 27(3) provides for compulsory abstention by a party to a dispute in decisions under Chapter VI and Article 52(3). This provision should not be applied automatically whenever a country is mentioned in an agenda topic. Chairs should seek the Responsible Secretariat Member's ruling on whether and how it applies in the simulation before the affected vote. [2]

Questions about an absent permanent member, disputed voting eligibility or the classification of an item should likewise be resolved before voting. Chairs should not treat absence as an automatically recorded vote or alter the threshold to match the number of delegations in the room.

The Right to Veto

Who May Exercise a Veto

The five permanent members of the Security Council—China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom and the United States of America—may block a substantive decision by voting against it. This is the right to veto. Non-permanent members do not hold this right, although their votes remain necessary in reaching the required nine affirmative votes. [2]

A veto applies to the substantive item actually being voted upon. If the vote concerns a resolution, the negative vote prevents adoption of that resolution as a whole. It does not simply remove the particular clause to which the permanent member objects. If the vote concerns a substantive amendment, the amendment fails; debate on the underlying resolution continues under the normal procedure. [4, 7]

Casting and Recording a Veto

A permanent member exercises a veto by voting against the substantive item during voting. There is no separate Motion to veto, additional placard or requirement to announce a veto in advance. An earlier statement of opposition indicates policy; the vote itself determines the result. [5]

The Chairs should record which permanent member or members voted against and announce the result accordingly. Fourteen votes in favour cannot override one permanent member's negative vote. Chairs do not exercise a veto of their own and should not disregard a valid vote because they consider the proposal useful.

Abstentions and Procedural Matters

A permanent member's abstention is not a veto. A substantive item may still pass if it receives nine affirmative votes and no permanent member votes against. A negative vote by a non-permanent member is also not a veto; it is counted against the proposal under the Council's voting rule. [2]

The veto does not apply to procedural decisions. Permanent members may oppose a procedural question, but the question can pass if it obtains nine affirmative votes. Distinguishing procedure from substance is therefore essential. The provisions on compulsory abstention and disputed classifications remain those explained in "Special Voting Questions". [4]

Responding to a Veto

A veto concludes the decision on that item; it does not automatically end the committee session. Delegates should identify the disputed wording and consider whether an alternative can address the objection while retaining sufficient support across the Council. Further consultation, revision or reintroduction requires the Chairs' direction and the normal submission procedure.

A Motion to retake the vote addresses an error in the voting procedure or count, rather than disagreement with a valid result. A Motion to Divide the House cannot cancel a veto. Delegates should pursue a change in the proposal or in negotiating positions through the normal debate process.

Practical Examples

Voting Examples

The following examples assume fifteen eligible Council members and no special voting arrangement. They illustrate how to apply the voting requirements rather than introduce additional motions.

Nine votes in favour, no votes against and six abstentions: the resolution is adopted, including where a permanent member is among those abstaining.

Eight votes in favour, no votes against and seven abstentions: the resolution is not adopted because it has not obtained nine affirmative votes.

Fourteen votes in favour and one vote against by a permanent member: the resolution is not adopted because of the permanent member's negative vote.

Nine votes in favour, one vote against by a non-permanent member and five abstentions: the resolution is adopted, provided that no permanent member has voted against.

Nine votes in favour and six votes against on a procedural question: the decision is adopted even if one or more permanent members vote against. For a substantive amendment with the same totals, the identity of the delegations voting against must be checked.

Amendment Example

Suppose clause 2 requests a report after thirty days. A delegation proposes replacing "thirty days" with "sixty days". The submission should identify clause 2, specify that the change is a replacement, and give the exact wording to be substituted.

The Chairs check and introduce the amendment, then move to Closed Debate. Delegates may discuss whether the revised deadline would improve implementation. The vote concerns that change only. If it passes, the displayed resolution is updated to sixty days; the resolution as a whole still requires a later vote.

Revising a Proposal after Rejection

If a proposal is not adopted, delegates should identify the reasons before drafting another version. Where time permits and the Chairs allow further negotiation, delegates may revise the disputed provisions and follow the normal submission and approval process. A failed item does not automatically return to the floor.

If a permanent member opposed the original wording, delegates may ask what revision could address that concern. They should also check whether the revised proposal can obtain sufficient support from the Council as a whole. A procedural Motion should not be used to disregard a valid substantive voting result.

Session Checklist and Final Remarks

For Delegates

Before the session, confirm your assigned country and whether it is a permanent member, read the Study Guide and relevant Council documents, and prepare proposals consistent with your country's position.

Before submitting a resolution or amendment, check its wording, mandate, implementation and numbering. Identify which changes are essential to your delegation and which can be negotiated.

Before voting, confirm the item under consideration and the final wording. Distinguish between abstaining and voting against, and assess the proposal as amended rather than relying on an earlier draft.

For Chairs

Before debate, complete Roll Call, verify quorum, explain the Council-specific voting requirements and confirm the amendment submission method. Ensure that all delegates can view the same working document.

Before entertaining a substantive change, check its scope and formatting and explain which text is under debate. Update the document only after the amendment has been adopted or a permitted minor correction has been agreed.

Before announcing a result, verify the totals, the nine-vote threshold and the votes of the permanent members. Record the outcome and explain the next stage of proceedings.

Final Remarks

The Council's voting system makes negotiation especially important, but every delegation contributes to the discussion and outcome. Delegates should explain their proposals and objections clearly. Chairs should apply the procedure consistently and ensure that the committee understands both the text being debated and the effect of its decisions.

If a Council-specific question is not resolved by this Manual or the general procedure, the Chairs should consult the Responsible Secretariat Member. Any resulting clarification should be communicated to the whole committee before it is applied.

References

The supplied MoMUN Student Officer Manual is the reference for the conference procedures retained in this supplement. The following official sources support the Council-specific explanations and provide further reading.

[1] MoMUN Code of Conduct. Open official source

[2] United Nations Security Council — Voting System. Article 27, permanent members and abstentions. Open official source

[3] Charter of the United Nations. Articles 23–25, 31–42 and 52. Open official source

[4] United Nations Security Council — Provisional Rules of Procedure. Rules 31–40. Open official source

[5] United Nations Dag Hammarskjöld Library — Voting Information. Open official source

[6] United Nations Dag Hammarskjöld Library — Security Council Membership. Open official source

[7] Repertoire of the Practice of the Security Council — Decision-making and Voting. Open official source